Memo: Which way should Brightwater run an AI assistant?

To: Maya Okafor

From: Daniel Reyes

Date: 28 February 2025

Decision wanted: at the kickoff meeting on 3 March 2025

Recommendation

I recommend Option C, a computer of our own running the assistant in the office. It is the most expensive of the three, but it is the only one that keeps client work inside the building, and two of our clients require that.

The three options

Option A: a cloud subscription

Each person pays £22 per user per month. For 12 people that is £264 per month, or £3,168 for the year. Nothing has to be bought or looked after. Our prompts and documents would be processed by the provider, in an EU region.

Option B: a hosted private instance

A provider in the UK runs an assistant for us alone at a flat £780 per month, or £9,360 for the year. Our data stays with that provider. Corvid Foods would have to agree to a change in its NDA first.

Option C: a workstation in our own office

A one-off cost of £2,330 (£2,150 for the workstation and £180 for a UPS battery unit) and £1,244 per month (a support retainer of £1,200, about £35 of electricity and £9 of cloud storage for backups). The first year costs £17,258. The second year would cost £14,928, because the one-off cost does not come back. Data never leaves the building.

Comparison

Option	One-off	Per month	First year	Where the data goes
A: cloud subscription	£0	£264	£3,168	Provider, EU region
B: hosted	£0	£780	£9,360	Provider, UK

private instance				
C: our own workstation	£2,330	£1,244	£17,258	Stays in our office

What matters most

- Two clients, Harbour and Pine and Corvid Foods, have NDAs that do not allow third parties to process their work. Option A would break both. Option B would break the Corvid Foods NDA unless it were changed.
- Option C costs £14,090 more than Option A in the first year. We accept that as the price of being able to take the work of both clients.
- Speed target: the 95th percentile of the time to the first word of an answer should be under 3 seconds. We will measure it before the pilot.
- Risk of Option C: one machine is a single point of failure. A nightly backup and a UPS battery unit reduce the risk, and Priya Nair will write down how to rebuild it.